The Akali Dal called for a general strike on 8 February 1984. Hindu shopkeepers in Punjab were forced to close their shops. To prevent loss of life and property, the government cancelled all train and air services to Punjab.

To deal with the situation arising out of the general strike, Akali leaders were once again called for negotiations on 14 February 1984, to which opposition leaders were also invited. On the same day, six policemen at a post near the Golden Temple were abducted by Bhindranwale's men. One of them was killed and the rest released after some time. Also on the same day, a general strike was called in Punjab by the Hindu Suraksha Samiti (Hindu Defence Committee) by its Patiala-based leader Pawan Kumar Sharma.

Authors Mark Tully and Satish Jacob described Pawan Kumar as '... a young man with a criminal record brought into politics by a Sikh Congress (Indira) member of Parliament. Pawan Kumar also had close links with the Haryana Chief Minister'. [13] But according to G.S Chawla, 'Seema Mustafa, then working for the *Telegraph* , Calcutta, had visited Patiala and interviewed the mother of Pawan Kumar Sharma, who said that she did not understand why the Maharaja Patiala, Amarinder Singh, was spoiling her son. Amarinder Singh's car used to pick up Pawan Kumar Sharma.' [14]

In the violence during that strike, fourteen persons were killed, mostly Sikhs. As a result, Akali leaders walked out of the negotiations saying they would return to the talks only when peace returned to Punjab.

Riots, and more killings

Following the Hindu Suraksha Samiti-led strike in Punjab, serious anti-Sikh riots broke out in the neighbouring state of Haryana, provoked by a speech by Chief Minister Bhajan Lal at Faridabad, in which he warned that the patience of Hindus was running out and they could retaliate any time. A gurudwara in Panipat was burnt down in the presence of the police. Sikhs were pulled out of buses and forcibly shaved, and Sikh-owned shops were looted. Eight Sikhs were clubbed to death. Considering the gravity of the situation, traffic on the main Grand Trunk Road had to be halted.